

- RAG Learning

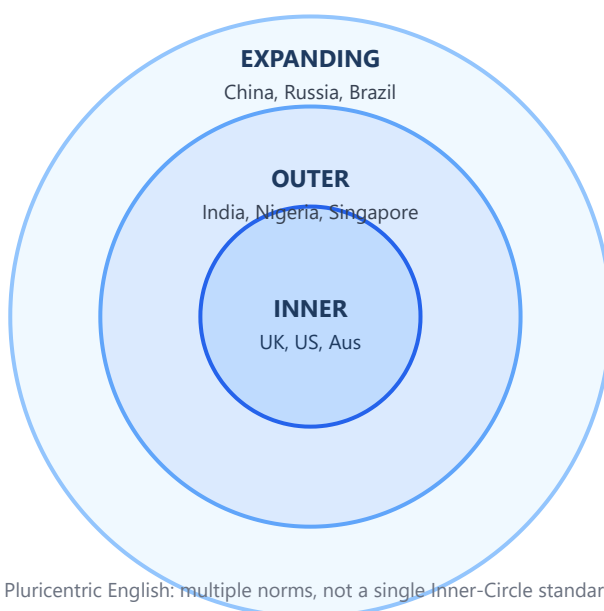
2.3 Language and Ethnicity / World Englishes

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 2 Section A

World Englishes studies how English has pluralised as a global language, developing distinct varieties with their own norms. Related work studies **ethnolects** — language varieties associated with ethnic groups — including MLE (Multicultural London English) and AAVE (African American Vernacular English). The core question: what status do these varieties deserve, and who decides?

2.3.1 Kachru's Three Circles

Kachru's Three Circles of World Englishes



Braj Kachru (1985) proposed three concentric circles describing the spread and status of English:

- **Inner Circle** — English as a native language (UK, US, Canada, Australia, New Zealand). Historically treated as the "norm-providing" centre.

- **Outer Circle** — English as an institutionalised second language, often a legacy of colonisation (India, Nigeria, Singapore, Ghana, Kenya). These varieties have their own developing norms.
- **Expanding Circle** — English as a foreign / international language (China, Russia, Brazil, Japan). Traditionally "norm-dependent" but increasingly developing local norms through ELF use.

Criticism: the model can reinforce Inner-Circle hegemony. Reality is fluid — many Expanding-Circle speakers are highly proficient; Indian English has its own pluricentric norms; boundaries blur.

2.3.2 English as a Lingua Franca (ELF) — Jenkins

Jennifer Jenkins argues that when English is used for communication between non-native speakers (which is the majority of English use globally), Inner-Circle norms are not the relevant target. She proposes a **Lingua Franca Core**: only certain phonological features are essential for intelligibility (e.g. consonant clusters), while others can vary without impeding communication (e.g. exact RP vowels).

Implication: "correct" English in ELF contexts is defined by intelligibility, not by conformity to a native-speaker accent.

2.3.3 Crystal and Pluricentric English

David Crystal has argued that English's global spread has produced multiple **new Englishes**, each with its own legitimate norms. The idea of a single "correct" English is incompatible with how the language is actually used worldwide: *Ethnologue* (2025) puts English at roughly **1.5 billion speakers**, of whom only about 390 million are native — so L2 users outnumber L1 users by roughly three to one, a point Crystal himself makes when he argues ownership of English has passed to its non-native majority. Crystal's position is broadly descriptivist and anti-hierarchy.

2.3.4 Translanguaging — García

Ofelia García's concept of **translanguaging** treats multilingual speakers as having a single integrated repertoire they deploy flexibly, rather than switching between bounded languages. This reframes what "code-switching" and "code-mixing" are: not switches between separate systems, but fluent use of a holistic resource.

Educational implication: pedagogy that affirms all of a learner's languages tends to produce better outcomes than English-only instruction for multilingual students.

2.3.5 African American Vernacular English (AAVE)

Labov's research

William Labov's work in Harlem (1972) demonstrated that AAVE is a **rule-governed, systematic variety** with its own grammar. Some key features:

Feature	Description	Example
Habitual "be"	Marks recurring/habitual action — distinct from Standard English "is"	"She be working" = she works regularly
Copula deletion	Omission of "is/are" in specific grammatical contexts	"She happy"
Remote past "been"	Stressed "been" marks long-completed action	"I been done my homework"
Negative concord	Multiple negation for emphasis	"Don't nobody know"
Reduction of consonant clusters	Final-cluster simplification	"tes" for "test"

Labov's work was influential in the Ann Arbor decision (1979), which ruled that schools had to acknowledge AAVE as a legitimate variety.

Ebonics debate (1996)

Oakland Unified School District proposed to recognise AAVE ("Ebonics") as the primary language of many Black students and to use it as a bridge to Standard English. Huge public backlash illustrated how linguistic facts (AAVE is rule-governed) are filtered through racialised ideologies.

2.3.6 Multicultural London English (MLE)

MLE emerged in late-20th / early-21st century London through dense multiethnic peer networks. Researched by **Jenny Cheshire**, **Paul Kerswill** and colleagues.

Features

- **Vowel shifts** — Cheshire and Kerswill's central finding is a *reversal* of the traditional London "Diphthong Shift": FACE and GOAT are produced as near-monophthongs with relatively open onsets (roughly [e:] and [o:] rather than Cockney [ʌɪ] and [ʌʊ]), and PRICE has a backed, raised onset (roughly [ɑɪ]) — a pattern resembling Caribbean and West African English. GOOSE is fronted (/u:/ → /ə:/), though this feature is acquired later in childhood than the others and is spreading across the wider South-East, not unique to MLE.
- **Lexis** — "ting" (thing), "mandem" (group of men), "wasteman" (useless person), drawn from Caribbean, South Asian, West African and vernacular London sources.
- **Grammar** — "man" as an indefinite pronoun ("man's tired"); new quotative "this is me" — "I was like...".
- **Prosody** — distinctive intonation contours.

Key finding: MLE is not one ethnicity's variety — features are shared across ethnic lines in inner-London peer networks. It is a *community of practice* variety.

Media representations ("jafaican", "street slang") often frame MLE pejoratively. This is a classic case of **standard-language ideology** — a legitimate rule-governed variety treated as a social threat.

2.3.7 Other World Englishes

Variety	Key features
Indian English	"Prepone" (opposite of postpone); progressive with stative verbs ("I am understanding"); invariant tag "isn't it?"
Singlish	Final particles "lah", "lor", "meh"; topic-prominent syntax; influence of Malay, Hokkien, Tamil, Cantonese

Nigerian English	"Go-slow" = traffic jam; distinctive modal use; loan lexis from Yoruba, Igbo, Hausa
Caribbean / Jamaican Creole	"Mi" for "I"; copula deletion; distinctive aspectual markers
Scots	Long history as a sister variety of English; strong grammatical and lexical distinctness.

2.3.8 Pidgins and Creoles

- **Pidgin** — a simplified contact language used between groups with no common language. No native speakers. Reduced grammar and lexis.
- **Creole** — a pidgin that has become a community's native language. Grammar and lexis expand to full capacity.
- **Decreolisation** — movement of a creole towards a prestige variety, producing a **lectal continuum** from basilect (furthest from standard) through mesolect to acrolect (closest).

2.3.9 Code-Switching and Code-Mixing

- **Code-switching** — alternating between varieties across clauses or turns. Functions: audience design, identity, topic, quotation.
- **Code-mixing** — mixing elements of different varieties within a clause. Common in multilingual communities (Hinglish, Spanglish).
- Both are skilled competences, not signs of confusion or deficit.

2.3.10 Vitality and Language Attitudes

Howard Giles proposed that varieties differ in **ethnolinguistic vitality**, which depends on:

- **Demographic strength** — number and density of speakers.
- **Institutional support** — schools, media, government recognition.

- **Status** — economic and cultural prestige.

Varieties with low vitality face potential decline. Attitudes shape vitality — positive media representation, education and policy can reinforce or erode a variety.

Applied Example: When British tabloids label MLE "jafaican", they are doing ideological work: implying MLE is fake / unauthentic / a threat. Cheshire's research shows MLE is a rule-governed, feature-sharing variety emerging from multiethnic peer networks — demonstrably authentic linguistic innovation. Analysing such representations is itself a Paper 2 Section B exercise (Language Discourses).

2.3.11 How to Analyse World Englishes Texts

1. Identify the **variety** and place it in Kachru's framework.
2. Analyse specific **phonological, lexical and grammatical features**.
3. Consider the **sociocultural context** — history, contact, identity.
4. Apply relevant **theorists**: Kachru, Crystal, Jenkins, Labov, Cheshire & Kerswill, García.
5. Evaluate **attitudes and representations** — is the variety stigmatised? Why?
6. Avoid deficit framing — all rule-governed varieties are linguistically legitimate.

Exam Tip: Engage with attitudes explicitly. A high-quality answer on MLE, AAVE or any world English acknowledges that these varieties are often subject to unfair stigma — AND explains why the stigma is linguistically unfounded. This is where AO1 (methods), AO2 (theory) and AO3 (context) meet.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **Kachru's Three Circles (Inner / Outer / Expanding), ELF, Lingua Franca Core, translanguaging, pluricentrism, ethnolect, MLE, AAVE, pidgin, creole, basilect / mesolect / acrolect, lectal continuum, code-switching, code-mixing, ethnolinguistic vitality, standard-language ideology.** Theorists: **Kachru, Crystal, Jenkins, Labov, Cheshire & Kerswill, García, Giles.**

